

Chapter 157-1: Ending (Part 1)

It was truly as she had said—Ning Fuyi slept soundly through the night. Although she was in the Demon Realm where sun and sky were never seen, her dreams were hazy and confused, always feeling as though she lay in summer breezes with flower fragrance brushing her face.

When she opened her eyes, her entire body felt indescribably comfortable, as if she had just been steamed and soaked in hot soup, soft and languid. She stretched lazily and slowly sat up, the hair piled on her shoulders flowing down like water.

The woman had already risen and was just stepping across the threshold, placing a pot of hot tea on the table.

She still wore yesterday's red clothes, her hair loosely bound behind her, cool and elegant. Seeing that Ning Fuyi had awakened, she brought the tea to the bedside and sat down sideways.

Her features magnified before her eyes, startlingly beautiful. Ning Fuyi reached out to take the teacup and drank the tea completely.

Chu Qingqiu raised her hand and naturally helped arrange her hair: "Do you want to wash and groom?"

Ning Fuyi shook her head and put down the teacup. Then demonic energy surged over her whole body, transforming her undergarments into black-gold silk robes, with a golden crown gathering her loose hair at the top of her head as she turned and got out of bed.

The woman's every movement was natural, not deliberately drawing close, but as if it had already become habit. Ning Fuyi didn't know the other's intentions, but she didn't reject it.

"What are the Demon Lord's plans for today?" Chu Qingqiu asked while lowering her head to help arrange Ning Fuyi's robe sash, looking up with peach blossom eyes¹, her body also drawing very close.

For a moment, Ning Fuyi felt as though she might sink into those eyes, but quickly withdrew her consciousness and looked away: "No particular plans."

"Then how about I take you outside to relax?"

"Relax? Leave the Demon Realm?" Ning Fuyi furrowed her brow warily, her hand unconsciously tightening around the wrist that was resting at her waist.

Chu Qingqiu felt some pain from her grip but didn't say much, only nodded.

Ning Fuyi suddenly laughed coldly: "Aren't you afraid that when those people discover this lord is a demon, they'll panic? If someone causes trouble because of this, this lord cannot guarantee their survival."

"They won't." The woman said lightly, then leaned forward. Seeing her approach, Ning Fuyi instinctively turned and retreated, backing several steps until she reached the edge of the table.

Red clouds rose beneath her phoenix eyes again, like a hedgehog that draws in its spikes at the slightest touch—the contrast was adorable. Chu Qingqiu suddenly developed thoughts she had never had before.

So she withdrew her hands and placed them on either side of the table, encircling the little demon between her arms, then watched as the red under her eyes spread across her entire face, even her earlobes taking on a bright hue.

Ning Fuyi felt somewhat dizzy. This woman before her appeared upright and unattainably noble, but once she became improper, relying solely on her appearance, she was more frightening than anyone.

Just as she was having wild thoughts, the woman suddenly grasped her waist and effortlessly lifted her up. Thus Ning Fuyi's body lightened for a moment, actually finding herself seated on the table.

Her hands frantically landed on the woman's shoulders—the thin shoulders were damp with fine perspiration, burning hot.

"What are you doing?" Ning Fuyi hurriedly spoke.

Chu Qingqiu's palms also broke out in fine sweat. She thought she could never do such things in this lifetime, but after some barrier that bound her whole body was broken, everything seemed less important.

"What do you think, Demon Lord?" Chu Qingqiu looked up at her, then pressed her down and planted a kiss on her lips.

Ning Fuyi was completely stunned, while Chu Qingqiu quickly moved her body away, cleared the tea implements, and said softly: "Let's go, Yiyi."

By the time the red clouds on Ning Fuyi's face had completely faded, she was already following Chu Qingqiu in a daze, standing outside the Demon Realm under the blazing scorching sun.

Beauty indeed could make one lose their reason. Ning Fuyi closed her eyes.

Having not seen the sun for a long time, she was somewhat unaccustomed to it and raised her sleeve to block it. Then a white umbrella appeared above her head. The umbrella wasn't thick, but it cast down an entire patch of shade.

The first realm the woman brought Ning Fuyi to was a mountain peak that towered into the clouds. Green grass flourished on the peak, flower seas clustered together, and several stone halls were scattered across the peak. The walls of the stone halls were covered with many vines that bloomed with white flowers.

A white tiger slept soundly in the flower bushes. Upon seeing Ning Fuyi, it raised its tail and licked the back of her hand, startling Ning Fuyi so much she almost drew the Xiangsi sword.

Ning Fuyi felt this place was somewhat familiar, yet also very strange. Familiar were those cold stone halls; strange was the profusion of flowers.

The second realm the woman brought Ning Fuyi to was an immortal sect. From time to time, cultivators would stand before her, frightening Ning Fuyi so much she hid tightly behind the woman, afraid of exposing her demonic energy.

But those people seemed very friendly. There were even several familiar young women who wept uncontrollably upon seeing her bewildered state, while the elder ones also reddened their eyes, extending their hands toward her for a long time before finally sighing deeply.

These faces seemed to have appeared in nightmares, but in the dreams they had been disgusted and hateful toward her, not friendly like this.

There was also a huge white dog that whined and bounced toward her embrace. Ning Fuyi nearly jumped into the woman's arms before awkwardly dodging away.

They quickly left this place and went to a third realm—a bustling street in the mortal world. Ning Fuyi concealed her demonic energy and walked among the mortals. It seemed close to some human festival, as every household had bundles of mugwort² tied in front of their doors, the fragrance drifting for miles.

The woman bought her sticky rice dumplings³ from the street vendors and even tied a five-colored silk thread around her wrist, saying it was used by mortals for prayers.

The thin thread was out of place on her wrist full of demonic weapons, but Ning Fuyi couldn't bear to remove it.

"What is this?" Ning Fuyi suddenly stopped, pointing to a temple with flourishing incense at the end of the long street.

Chu Qingqiu looked toward that temple—outside the black-tiled, red-walled temple was a sea of people, swallows occasionally flew past under the eaves, and the sandalwood fragrance was serene and quiet.

"Mountain River Temple⁴." Chu Qingqiu answered. She lowered her head and took Ning Fuyi's hand, leading her toward the temple.

Because they had changed their appearances, the passing people didn't recognize them. Ning Fuyi had originally been somewhat wary of the palm Chu Qingqiu extended, but that cool hand interlocked with her ten fingers, softer than she had imagined.

So Ning Fuyi didn't struggle free and followed her across the threshold into the temple. She saw two divine statues standing in the hall—one person held a jade staff and wore snow-white clothes, while the other was dressed in black robes, grasping a sword that glowed with pink light.

Ning Fuyi blinked several times, then frowned: "This sword isn't it..."

She looked down at the Xiangsi hanging at her waist. The current Xiangsi hadn't been awakened and appeared in a translucent jade color. She then turned to stare at Chu Qingqiu's profile, finding them quite similar in comparison.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling." Ning Fuyi read the name carved on the base of flower petals. "Little White, you greatly resemble this person."

"If you two aren't going to worship, then don't block others' incense offerings!" At this time, a temple priest in gray cloth approached with a broom, urging them: "There's a long line outside!"

"Pah, what kind of people are they that I should kneel and offer incense?" Ning Fuyi became angry upon hearing this and cursed disdainfully.

"You person, how can you be disrespectful to the two venerables! Mountain River Temple was established by all the immortal sects and naturally venerates supreme venerables. To blaspheme the venerables—do you want your lifespan shortened?" The temple priest also had a bad temper and waved his broom to drive them away.

Seeing the two were about to quarrel, Chu Qingqiu waved her hand and sent out immortal energy to seal the temple priest's mouth, then wrapped around Ning Fuyi's waist. In the blink of an eye, she pulled her out of the temple and landed on the street outside.

"Why did you stop me?" Ning Fuyi still wanted to go forward but was pulled back by Chu Qingqiu.

"Enough!" Chu Qingqiu scolded.

Normally Ning Fuyi wouldn't listen to anyone's words, but at Chu Qingqiu's single scolding, she immediately quieted down, only her mouth was still puffed out.

Seeing her like this, Chu Qingqiu reached out and pinched both sides of her cheeks. With a "puff" sound, she squeezed out the air inside.

"Why are you arguing with mortals? Besides, didn't you already guess who the venerated ones are?" Chu Qingqiu struggled hard to suppress her laughter.

Ning Fuyi's mouth opened and closed without speaking. Instead, she suddenly turned around with her back to Chu Qingqiu, her eyes flickering uncertainly.

In this year since gaining consciousness, why had she never suspected her own identity? The fragmentary words of those people in the Demon Realm, their strange attitudes toward her, all made her constantly suspect just who she was.

But for some unknown reason, from the moment she opened her eyes, she had a strong sense of distrust toward everything around her. She feared everyone who approached her, performed as the Demon Lord with trepidation, was irritable and angry, and didn't believe anyone's words.

Over time, no one mentioned the Demon Lord's past anymore.

Yet she still felt afraid—afraid of everything around her. She knew she was called Ning Fuyi, but didn't know if she truly was Ning Fuyi. Whenever she slept, she would have nightmares where she was rejected and humiliated by everyone.

Besides this, there was also a figure in white in her dreams.

So she finally relented and allowed an immortal woman to come close to her. She wanted to know who she was.

Footsteps approached from behind, and her hand was taken again. Soft fingers like small snakes nimbly burrowed into each of her finger gaps as the woman pulled her toward the outskirts of the city.

Footnotes:

¹ **Peach blossom eyes** - A Chinese description for particularly alluring, slightly upturned eyes that are considered very attractive

² **Mugwort** - An aromatic plant traditionally hung during the Dragon Boat Festival for protection against evil spirits

³ **Sticky rice dumplings** - Traditional food eaten during the Dragon Boat Festival, also called zongzi

⁴ **Mountain River Temple** - A fictional temple in the story, likely dedicated to the protagonists' past lives as deities